

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ -
 ♥ 10 8 7 3
 ♦ K J 9 4
 ♣ K 8 6 5 2

♠ K Q J 9 6 5 4

♥ A 4

♦ A 5 2

♣ 7

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 10 2
 ♥ K Q J 5 2
 ♦ Q 10 8
 ♣ 9 4 3

♠ A 8 7 3

♥ 9 6

♦ 7 6 3

♣ A Q J 10

West	North	East	South
	1 ♠	Pass	3 ♠
Pass	4NT	Pass	5 ♥
Pass	6 ♠		
All Pass			

6 ♠ by North

♥ loser. East may be able to win the trick but you can ruff a ♥ return, and dummy will have two good ♣s on which you can discard 2 ♦ losers.

North is to play 6 ♠. East leads the ♥ K.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=2 ♣=0 Total = 3

Your only hope for ridding yourself of two of those losers is dummy's ♣ suit. One possibility would be to finesse East for the ♣K, and if that works, discard your ♥ loser on the ♣A. You could then establish another ♣ winner for one of the ♦ losers. The problem with that plan is that if the finesse fails the defense will immediately take the setting ♥ trick.

A better plan is a ruffing finesse. Win the first trick with your ♥A and pull trumps with your ♠ K Q.

Next play your ♣7 to dummy's ♣A. Then lead the ♣Q from dummy. If West plays the ♣K you will ruff, enter dummy, and discard two red losers on the ♣ J 10. If West plays low instead, you discard your

Ruffing finesses sometimes provide you the best opportunity, like this time.

But they are easy to overlook, mainly because we don't use them often.

Board 3

West Deals

None Vul

♠ K J 3

♥ Q 7 3

♦ K Q J 9 5

♣ 8 4

♠ 9 4 2

♥ A 10 5

♦ 7 6 3

♣ A K 6 5



♠ 10 8 7 6

♥ 8 6 4 2

♦ 8 2

♣ 10 7 3

♠ A Q 5

♥ K J 9

♦ A 10 4

♣ Q J 9 2

West

1 ♦

Pass

All Pass

3NT by South

The ♠ A is your ninth trick.

North

Pass

3NT

East

Pass

South

1NT

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♦ K.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=4 Total = 8

You only need one more winner. If East has the ♠ K you can finesse him out of it. Or, you have a two-way finesse for the ♥ Q.

It is an easy choice. The defenders only have 12 HCP and West opened the bidding. So you know he must have both of the cards you are interested in.

Hold up the ♦ A until the third round just to be safe. Then play four rounds of ♣ s ending in your hand.

Now play the ♥ J. If West doesn't cover, you will let it ride for your ninth trick. But West does cover so you take dummy's ♥ A, then your other 2 ♥ tricks.

You might think that a two-way finesse offers you a 50% chance of guessing correctly.

Sometimes that may be right. But there are other times when information from the bidding or the opening lead allows you to make a higher-percentage guess.

Board 5

South Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 10 9 8
♥ A Q 3
♦ 10 9 6 3 2
♣ 9 7

♠ Q 6 5 3

♥ 7 4 2

♦ A K

♣ Q J 5 4

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K 2

♥ K J 8 5

♦ J 8 7 4

♣ 10 6 3

♠ A J 7 4

♥ 10 9 6

♦ Q 5

♣ A K 8 2

West	North	East	South
			1 ♣
Pass	1 ♠	Pass	2 ♠
Pass	4 ♠		
All Pass			
4 ♠ by North			
♠ 10 later.			

North is to play 4 ♠. East leads the ♥ 5. The defense wins 3 ♥ tricks, then switches to a ♦.

Losers: ♠ = ? ♥ = 3 ♦ = 0 ♣ = 0 Total = 3 ?

You have already lost the 3 ♥ tricks so you must pick up the trump suit without loss. The odds aren't in your favor, but you have no choice but to play East for the doubleton King.

Lead a small ♠ from your hand and when East plays low put on the ♠ J. When this holds the trick plunk down the ♠ A and hope.

This position is one that is misplayed very often.

Look what would have occurred if you had started with the ♠ Q. East would have covered with the ♠ K (if he had it) and you would have lost a trick to the

The only hope is to try to drop the ♠ K without wasting an extra honor.